

LOGGED IN
A gamer at a gaming parlour in Dwarka, New Delhi

Location Courtesy United Gamers Network

RAJWANT RAWAT



"SETTING UP THE ANIMATION, VISUAL EFFECTS, GAMING AND COMICS (AVGC) PROMOTION TASK FORCE WILL HELP INDIA ACHIEVE ITS POTENTIAL OF CREATING 20 LAKH JOBS"

JEHIL THAKKAR
Partner and Media and Entertainment Sector Leader, Deloitte India

industry to grow to $3.9 billion (Rs 29,396 crore) by 2025 in India.

Presenting the Union budget on February 1, finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman said that the government is planning to set up an Animation, Visual Effects, Gaming and Comics (AVGC) promotion task force to recommend ways to employ youth and build domestic capacity to serve the Indian markets and global demand. As per the Confederation of Indian Industry and the Boston Consulting Group, India has less than 10 per cent of the global market share in VFX (visual effects) and animation at present. "The setting up of the task force will help India achieve its potential of creating 20 lakh jobs, according to Deloitte projections," says Jehil Thakkar, partner, and media and entertainment sector leader, Deloitte India. "These are critical skills for growth of the metaverse and India is poised to take advantage of this ecosystem." The metaverse is an online, 3D universe that combines multiple virtual spaces. Considered a future iteration of the internet, the metaverse allows users to work, meet, game and socialise together in these 3D spaces. In January, the government of Karnataka launched an AVGC Centre of Excellence in Bengaluru which also has a finishing school that offers courses on emerging technologies in these areas.

FROM PRODUCT TO EXPERIENCE

In April 2021, Accenture said that the value of the global gaming industry was more than the combined market for movies and music, driven by a surge in mobile gaming and an emphasis on social interaction during the pandemic. China, Japan, the UK and US were the world's largest gaming markets. A whopping 2.7 billion people played games globally, with another 400 million expected to join the fray by the end of 2023. Of the new joinees, 60 per cent were women, and 30 per cent were under the age of 25. "The emergence of new gaming platforms and changing demographics are pushing gaming businesses away from being product-centric to becoming experience-oriented platforms," says Seth Schuler, managing director, Accenture's Software and Platforms industry group.

PUBG, the popular battle game from Chinese firm Tencent, used to be the favourite among Indian gamers until it was banned by the Indian government along with several other Chinese apps following border tensions with China in 2020. Free Fire, developed by Vietnamese firm 111dots Studio and published by Singapore's Garena, gained in popularity following the PUBG ban, but this app was also banned by India recently citing a potential misuse of user data. However, the second version of the game, Free Fire Max